Human-made Things in the Bible © United Bible Societies, 2025. Adapted from: The Works of Their Hands: Man-made Things in the Bible, by Ray Pritz © 2009 United Bible Societies. This work is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/).

Tongs

4.4.3 Tongs

References:

Hebrew מֶלְקָחַיִם (melqachayim) EXO 25:38, EXO 37:23, NUM 4:9, 1KI 7:49, 2CH 4:21, ISA 6:6

Hebrew מַעֲצָד (maʿatsad) ISA 44:12

Description and usage:

Tongs (Gary Todd, Israel Museum, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons)A pair of tongs was a metal tool that was U-shaped. The user held the tool near its closed end; by squeezing its two arms together, it was possible to pick up hot coals or other objects. Tongs may be thought of as a large version of the tweezers often used today for plucking hairs or removing thorns or splinters.

Translation:

The Hebrew word *melqachayim* always refers to an implement used by the priests. Except for ISA 6:6, where no material is specified, they were all made of gold, and they were used in connection with the lamps of the Tabernacle and Temple. Some commentators understand the word *melqachayim* in these passages to refer to a smaller set of tongs used to adjust or remove the wicks in the lamps (see 4.3.4.1 Snuffer, wick trimmer<REALIA:4.3.4.1> and 5.1 Oil lamp and wick<REALIA:5.1>). So in this context it would be a kind of "pincers" or large tweezers.

The Hebrew word *ma'atsad* in ISA 44:12 refers to tongs similar in construction to those used in the Tabernacle and Temple. The pair of tongs in this verse, however, was used by a blacksmith to hold hot metal while he worked on it.